

THREE INDESPENSABLE ELEMENTS OF EFFECTIVENESS

INTRO: I think I could safely say that everyone in the room wants to be effective as opposed to being ineffective. Even though most people desire to be highly effective many of those people eventually settle for mediocrity. I must ask myself the question what would cause a life full of promise to settle for anything less than the best? I think several factors contribute to a person settling for less than ultimate effectiveness:

- Prayerlessness: If you are a person of prayer, you will pray through a lot of problems and a lot of false reports in your life. If you are a person who has to be required to have a prayer time you will eventually believe a false report, and will make a string of bad decisions that will render your ministry ineffective.
- A deficiency of the Word of God: The Word of God is not only our spiritual nourishment but is the roadmap to a highly effective life. If you are going somewhere you must follow the map; if you are going to follow the map you must first familiarize yourself with it. (Experience in Portland Oregon)
- Loss of faith in the dream: Everyone begins life with a dream. (I began life with a dream & at 43 I am actually living part of my dream) The loss of faith in the dream is sometimes due to a string of temporary setbacks; a lack of persistence; believing the lie of the enemy.

I think it is a tragedy for a life full of promise to settle for ineffectiveness or mediocrity.

There are two things people will never forgive you for:

- Success: If you succeed the general public will be uncomfortable with you because it points up their ineffectiveness or mediocrity. When you begin to experience success people will line up around the block in an attempt to bring you back down to their level. If you continue to make a move toward effectiveness many of your friends will begin to distance themselves from you.
- Failure: If you fail they will be like piranhas attacking the prey. (Experience with chickens on the farm) Most people mask their own unhappiness with their unfulfilled dreams by tearing other people down.

In my opinion the very idea of being average should make everyone in this room extremely uncomfortable. If you can be happy being mediocre or ineffective you should submit a resignation today, you are in the wrong place.

The question should be asked what is the difference between being effective, ineffective, or average?

I. LISTENING: The subject I am speaking on today is extremely important to the overall goal, which is effective ministry. I want to look at three aspects of listening.

- Listen to God: When speaking to the seven churches of Asia in the book of Revelation the Lord said “... ***he that hath an ear, let him hear what the Spirit is saying to the churches.***” If you are going to have any measure of effectiveness you must train the ear of your Spirit not only to hear what God is saying but also to be able to sense when He is wanting to say something. A major component of

listening to God is sensitivity. During your private prayer time don't fill the entire time with your words, set aside some time to listen to what God is saying.

- Listen to those closest to you: Don't go through life barking orders, learn to listen to some trusted advisers. The Scripture says there is “...*wisdom in a multitude of counselors*”. Rather than intimidating those around you, release them to tell you the truth. Sometimes the truth can be somewhat painful. Even though the truth can cut pretty deep it is capable of making you better, thus more effective.
- Listen to what others are saying about you: Believe it or not, everyone who steps into a leadership role will attract detractors. As tempted as you will be to do so you cannot totally discount what your detractors have to say about you. If you take everything they say to heart you will be so discouraged you will not be able to continue in ministry; on the other hand, you must always remember there is an element of truth to what they are saying or it would be totally unbelievable. In such cases you must extract the truth, evaluate it, and improve your serve as a result of that analysis.

If you train yourself to listen to God, listen to those closest to you, and listen to others you will continually be in possession of enough truth about yourself that a personal growth plan will automatically emerge.

Let me ask you a question; are you more inclined to talk or listen? Those who lead are often called on to speak; give a statement; asked for an opinion; give direction; give advice; the amount of time required for listening will be determined by the amount of time required in speaking! The biggest six letter word in the vocabulary of an effective person is **LISTEN!**

II. ACCOUNTABILITY: For some people accountability is a difficult word to pronounce, and even more difficult to accept. The only reason I know of that a person would reject accountability is because they have something to hide.

Accountability is the friend of effectiveness. The more accountability you set up in your life, the better the chances of effectiveness. Someone once said “Power corrupts, and absolute power absolutely corrupts.” Those of us who are in leadership positions need to be accountable in the following ways:

- Accountable to God! Never forget “There is an all seeing eye watching you.”
- Accountable to your mate and family! If you fail to be accountable in this area your effectiveness will never be what it could have been. God created the family to produce and facilitate the human race. In addition to those things the family was established to create close fellowship between human beings, and provide a very natural system of accountability.
- Accountable to others! Government, laws, church, and organization you work for. (Song: When we all pull together) Everything you do affects me; everything I do affects you; you are my business. (Achan)

The lack of accountability often restricts effectiveness, and keeps goals from being realized. 28 years ago Jean Nidetch was an overweight homemaker desperate to lose

weight. She had tried almost everything with very little success. After two months of attempting a diet prescribed by her doctor, she still needed to lose in excess of 50 pounds. Her desperation caused her to call on a real life experience from her childhood. She remembered walking through a park as a teenager and seeing children setting in swings as their mothers were huddled together gossiping. She would give the children a push and they would use their effort to do the rest. Jean assembled a group of six overweight friends and together they accomplished their goal. Now 28 years later more than one million people meet in 25 countries of the world in what has become known as Weight Watchers meetings.

Accountability is not your enemy it is your friend. In fact: It is one of the few keys to your effectiveness.

III. CREATIVITY

God has gifted each one of us in a very unique way. His gifting is not a random act of kindness, but a gift of purpose. The Scriptures tell us that we were ***“Fearfully and wonderfully made”***; that verse means that we were ***“thoughtfully and reverently made”***.

In the parable of the talents everyone had at least one talent. Everyone has a gift; some have more than others! Everyone has more than they initially know!

It is my opinion that with the gifting God has placed within each of us comes with a fringe benefit of creativity. Some people never find a way to release their creativity and therefore live a very frustrated life. Creativity is the voice of the gift; it is the action component of the gift; it is the method of expression without which the gift will remain virtually silent. A gift without creativity equals a life without purpose.

When you allow your gift to begin to express itself with creativity it will develop a ministry with meaning. Someone said a persons ***“Gift will make a place for them”***. Undiscovered talent is often revealed through the release of creativity.

Massive amounts of incubation time are required in prayer, meditation, and planning before the gift can give birth to creativity. (It is like a chicken sitting on eggs in her nest – A pregnant woman)

The gift alone will not open doors for you and will not allow for effective ministry. Effective ministry is initiated when the gift begins to speak out through creativity. Creativity will only manifest itself when all the other ingredients are in place; and only when the recipient of the gift steps up to the plate and overcomes the fear of failure and begins to implement the ideas God has placed within their hearts.

Why do you suppose God cared enough to uniquely gift each of us? He had a purpose! Are you on your way to fulfilling that purpose? If not, why not? I release you in the name of Jesus to operate in your giftedness and to begin to create things that will have value to this church and to the Kingdom of God.

History reveals that most things of real value were invented by the most unlikely of people.

- Thomas Edison invented the light bulb!
- Henry Ford invented the automobile!
- The Wright brothers gave us the gift of aviation!

None of these people succeeded on their first attempt!

If at first you don't succeed, try, try again! When you fail, evaluate your actions keep the good and rid yourself of the bad! I did not quit eating watermelon just because it has seeds! I eat the watermelon and spit out the seeds!

I am convinced that no-one in this room knows what they are really capable of; God will reveal it little by little as we release creativity, and overcome the fear of failure.